

S12: Critical Responses

A large group of male students, likely Year 12, are posed in multiple rows in front of a brick building with arched windows. They are all wearing dark blue school blazers over white shirts and blue and white striped ties. Some students have a small blue crest on their blazers. The students are looking directly at the camera with neutral expressions.

Art [&&] Impact · Week 8

In This Session

BLOCK	CONTENT	DURATION	AI ZONE
Lecture	Critical Responses	45 min	● No AI
Activity	AI habits check-in (in your group)	10 min	● No AI
Activity	Portfolio peer review (between groups)	40 min	● No AI
Activity	Space & technical requirements	10 min	● Brain-first
On-Demand	Crisis Helpdesk <i>(optional)</i>	—	● Brain-first

*Brief reminder that unstructured time is a group responsibility.
Providing more group time comes with the expectation that you make use of it!*

Where We Are

← LAST (S11)

Staging the Experience
+ UX Trial #2

What the room adds · Second round
of audience feedback

Something that runs

 TODAY (S12)

Critical Responses

How to give and take critique ·
Portfolio peer review · Draft your
exhibition needs

Buddychecks can be submitted
(whole week)

→ NEXT (S13)

Sound, Accessibility
& Technical Review

Thursday · Submit space and
technical requirements!

Phase 2 ends on Friday (S14)

Critical Responses

A structured way of helping someone see how their work is experienced.

What a Critical Response Is For

NOT A VERDICT OR FINAL ASSESSMENT

Critique is not deciding whether the work is good. It is describing what the work does to the person in front of it.

Verdicts close the work down.

Good responses open it up!

TWO HARD JOBS

If you are giving it: describe what you notice before you say what you think it means.

If you are receiving it: listen before you defend your artistic intention. It's hard to listen while trying to explain.

*Feedback often fails because **both sides** skip straight to their positions*

Critical Response Process: an Introduction

with CRP creator Liz Lerman and co-author John Borstel

Critical Response Process (CRP)

4-step method for giving and receiving feedback on creative work in process.

It starts with **a question posed by the artist about their work to the audience.** — e.g. “What was exciting?”

1 – STATEMENTS OF MEANING

Thoughtful Response

Artists will have posted a question; responders first state what was meaningful, surprising, or memorable.

2 – ARTIST ASKS QUESTIONS

Ask → Audience

The maker asks the audience about their responses; and they answer however they want, but stay strictly on topic.

3 – NEUTRAL QUESTIONS

Ask → Artist

Responders ask questions to the artist, but neutrally; without opinion hidden inside.

4 – OFFERING PERMISSIONED OPINIONS

Sharing

Responders offer “I have an opinion about X; would you like to hear it?”. Artist can accept or ask to focus on a different part.

Roleplay Example

“Can’t Help Myself” — Sun Yuan & Peng Yu · 2016

We’ll roleplay the Critical Response Process briefly.
I’ll be the artist, you’ll be the audience!

**But let’s take it step by step.
Starting with a deep-dive into step 1.**



1

Statements of Meaning

Thoughtful Response

Artists will have posted a question; responders first state what was meaningful, surprising, or memorable.

Step 1: Statements of Meaning

Roleplay: Statements of Meaning

As an artist, I ask you:

What is your first reaction when seeing my work?

As the responding audience, you:

1. Think about the question first.
2. Try to park your opinions and focus on the question
3. In this case: reflecting on your **reaction** - emotional, physical
4. Point out what made the **initial reaction** meaningful, surprising, or memorable

Notice that this takes time and effort on both sides!



2

Artist Asks Questions

Ask → Audience

The maker asks the audience about their responses; and they answer however they want, but **stay strictly on topic.**

Step 2: the Artist Asks Questions

Roleplay: Artist Asks Questions

As an artist, I ask you:

What did you think about my choice of having a **robot** wipe the floor?

As the responding audience, you:

1. Think about the question first.
2. Reflect on the elements that were contained in the question.
3. Try to be as open as possible; but limit your statements to your own perception; not general 'truths'
4. Engage with what the artist appears to focus on in their question.

*Notice that the artist likely wants to know more about something **they** care about!*



3

Neutral Questions

Ask → Artist

Responders ask questions to the artist, but neutrally; without opinion hidden inside.

Step 3: Neutral Questions

Roleplay: Neutral Questions

As the audience, you now have **questions**:

... think of something! ...

As the question-asking audience, you:

1. Formulate a genuine question you have.
2. If it is opinionated, think about how it can be posed neutrally.
3. Actively take on a **curious** mindset; you want to **understand** the artist in this step

Hold off on opinions you want to share until the next step!



4

OFFERING PERMISSIONED OPINIONS

Sharing

Responders offer “*I have an opinion about X; would you like to hear it?*”

Artist can accept or ask to focus on a different part.

Step 4: Permissioned Opinions

Roleplay: Offering Permissioned Opinions

As the audience, you can now ask to offer opinions:

*I have an opinion about _____
– would you like to hear it?*

As the question-asking audience, you:

1. Start by explicitly asking if the maker **wants** to hear your opinion about a topic that's on your mind
2. They might agree or may ask if you have opinions on a different topic
3. Not being open to discuss some topics is valid – we are trying to support a creation process; not to provide an assessment



Critical Responses

THE GOAL

Not to suggest a different piece. To help the maker see the piece they already have more clearly.

A good response leaves them knowing **one thing they didn't know before**.

ALSO FOR PORTFOLIO FEEDBACK

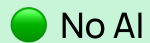
Your portfolio is creative work and a reader is an audience too — the same person who will have visited your installation in the room.

Make use of this feedback process in your next UX Trial, and to improve your portfolio!

*Bad critique seeks to rebuild the work in the critic's taste.
Good critique hands it back, but in sharper form.*

Activity:

AI Habits Check-In



No AI



10min

AI Habits Check-In

Discuss in your team (person-by-person):

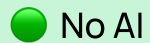
- Look through your own “AI & Me” records and share your experience with the group.
- What changed about how you used AI across Phase 2, compared to Phase 1?
- Is the group unified in how to use or NOT use AI across different deliverables?
- Where will it be used and how? Where not and why not?
- What counts as AI use for each of you?

10:00

Start

Edit

Activity: Portfolio Peer Review



No AI



10min > 15min > 15min

Portfolio Peer Review: Reading

Swap your **current portfolio draft** with another team. Read each other's portfolio for **10 minutes** and take notes about it. Describe first — hold off on opinions or verdicts.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

- Do you find the portfolio easy to navigate and understand?
- Does it make you curious to keep reading more?
- Does it feel academic or personal?

STATEMENT & CONCEPT

- Do you get a feeling for what position the group wants to express?
- Do you get an idea about what the group wants to create?

UX TRIAL REPORTS

- Do you understand what questions the group tested?
- Is it clear what they observed and what changed as a result?
- Can you tell how the trials contribute to a clearer installation concept?
- Anything you find surprising or noteworthy?

10:00



Start

Edit

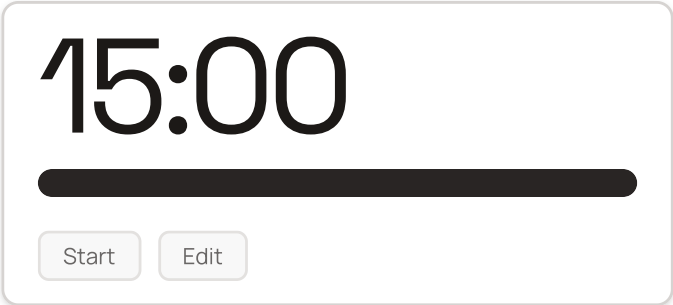
Portfolio Peer Review: Discussion (Round 1)

Now it's time to discuss! **15 Minutes** of time to focus on the portfolio of one group.

PORTFOLIO AUTHORS: POSE A QUESTION YOU WANT TO KNOW

1. **Statements of Meaning** — Readers answer and note what was meaningful, surprising, or memorable.
2. **Authors Ask Questions** — Dig deeper about what readers just told you
3. **Neutral Questions** — Now readers ask authors about they were curious about
4. **Permissioned Opinions** — Readers offer to share opinions, if welcome!

... 15 minutes, then we swap between authors and readers!



15:00

Start

Edit

Portfolio Peer Review: Discussion (Round 2)

Swap: now it's about the other group. **15 Minutes** of time to focus on the portfolio of the other group.

PORTFOLIO AUTHORS: POSE A QUESTION YOU WANT TO KNOW

1. **Statements of Meaning** — Readers answer and note what was meaningful, surprising, or memorable.
2. **Authors Ask Questions** — Dig deeper about what readers just told you
3. **Neutral Questions** — Now readers ask authors about they were curious about
4. **Permissioned Opinions** — Readers offer to share opinions, if welcome!

15:00

Start

Edit

Activity:

Space & technical requirements

 Brain-first

 10min

Draft Your Space & Tech Needs

🕒 10 min

As a team — rough is fine. Results of this discussion are needed on Thursday (S13)

PUT A FIRST ANSWER ON EACH

- **Footprint** — how much floor do you need?
- **Darkness** — dark space, light space?
- **Sound** — silent, ambient, or loud?
- **Equipment & power** — what, and roughly how much draw?

REMEMBER FROM S9

- Both rooms are **shared** — you build your own separation if needed — but also: careful with segmenting everything into sub-cubicles 😊
- Space isn't split evenly by team: the strength of your statement and UX trials is part of your **argument** for what you need

Arrive at S13 with a draft, not a blank slate. You'll formalize and argue it on Thursday.

10:00

Start

Edit

By Friday ...

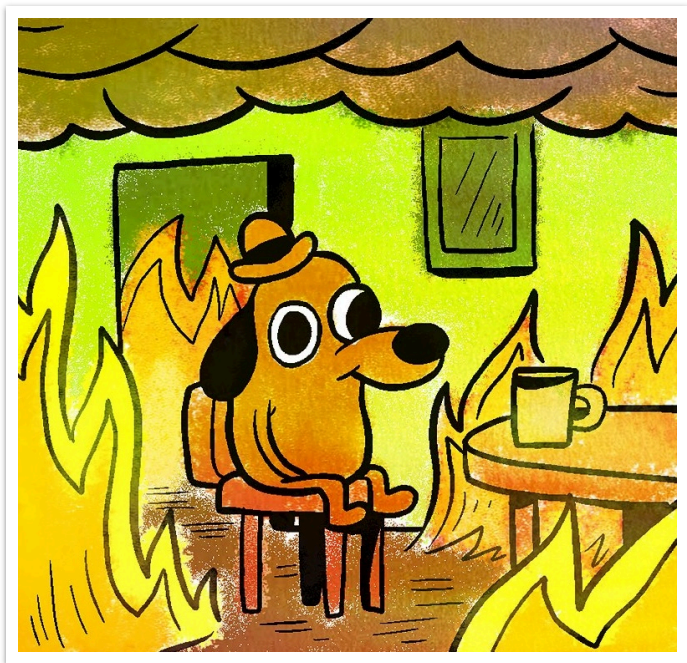
PHASE 2 DELIVERABLES – DUE FRI 23:59 (S14)

- UX Trial Reports (*min. 3 trials covered; in Portfolio*)
- Installation Concept section (*in Portfolio*)
- Technical Decisions section (*in Portfolio*)
- AI & Me section
(*min. two Phase 2 interactions; individual submission*)
- Buddycheck 2 (*individual submission*)

ACT ON FEEDBACK

You got feedback from another team AND got feedback in Phase 1 from the teaching team. **Act on it!**

The portfolio is in iteratively changing document; don't neglect parts that were 'already done' – they remain part of how you present your project!



Crisis Helpdesk

Optional, let us know!

Got a **critical blocker** – something that stops progress?

Bring a **specific problem**, not a general *“it’s not going well.”*
The more precisely you can name what’s stuck, the faster we can help.

Art [88] Impact

See you Thursday at S13.